

TAAVI REKKARO

13.10.–12.11.2023

aitäh kõrge eest

Tartu Kunstimaja
Monumentaalgalerii

TARTU KUNSTIMAJA
K-E 12-18

TARTU ART HOUSE
WED-MON 12-18

VANEMUISE 26, TARTU
TASUTA / FREE

TARTU



Taavi Rekkaro

aitäh kõige eest
/thanks for everything

Photos from Tallinn 2022,
Tartu 2023
and Oslo 2024



"stars, they go like the last light of the sun, all in a blaze"
Framed as custom diptych ~105x140cm. Archival inkjet print, framed with museum glass.
2021



"i knew myself better than i do now"
Framed as custom diptych ~105x140cm. Archival inkjet print, framed with museum glass.
2021

Exhibition introduction text:

When a long-term relationship suddenly ends, the artist discovers himself in a complete emptiness. His partner takes all her things and when she leaves then all the meanings leave with her.

Only the good-bye message "thanks for everything" left on the mirror reminds the artist of the fact that a certain world has existed somewhere at some time before. From the mirror, I am facing life that seems to have failed for good. I have studied a specialty that is now just a diploma for me and not my calling. My long-time loved one has found herself a better partner. My room is empty.

What would be your last straw if you'd lose everything?

A journey of a drowning man begins where art serves as the last tower of strength instead of self-expression. A lifebuoy to which to cling. Documenting self-pity, implacability, fussiness and growth is a path that one can follow only alone.

What does the drowning man see?

Winter reflecting from the books of the former loved one.

The undone bed that still remembers the warmth of the partner who has left.

Frames turned upside down, taken off the wall but that have not left the room.

Incoherent pain that wants to become words.

But also the study material for growing plants and survival drive.

This is letting go and recording of letting go.

Being reborn while wishing to bring the old life with me. Moving along the circle and hoping that it is a spiral. Perhaps it is?

thank you for leaving me in darkness

thank you for teaching me how to breathe

thank you for getting and giving and getting everything
with you

I am angry happy

I will never make peace and

I have already forgiven

thank you for everything

"Exhibition text: Joonas Veelmaa"



"dividing pain, trying again"
40x56cm, Archival inkjet print, framed with museum glass.
2022



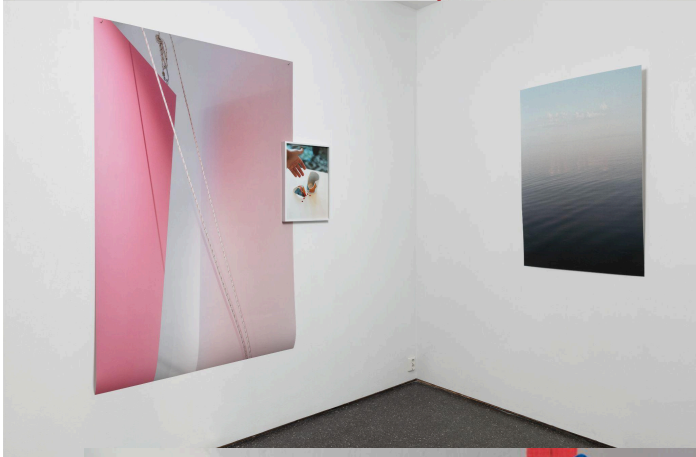
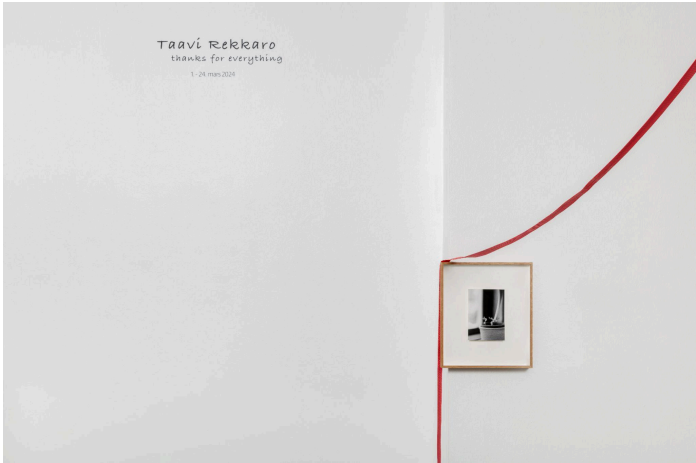
Exhibition views, Tartu 2023

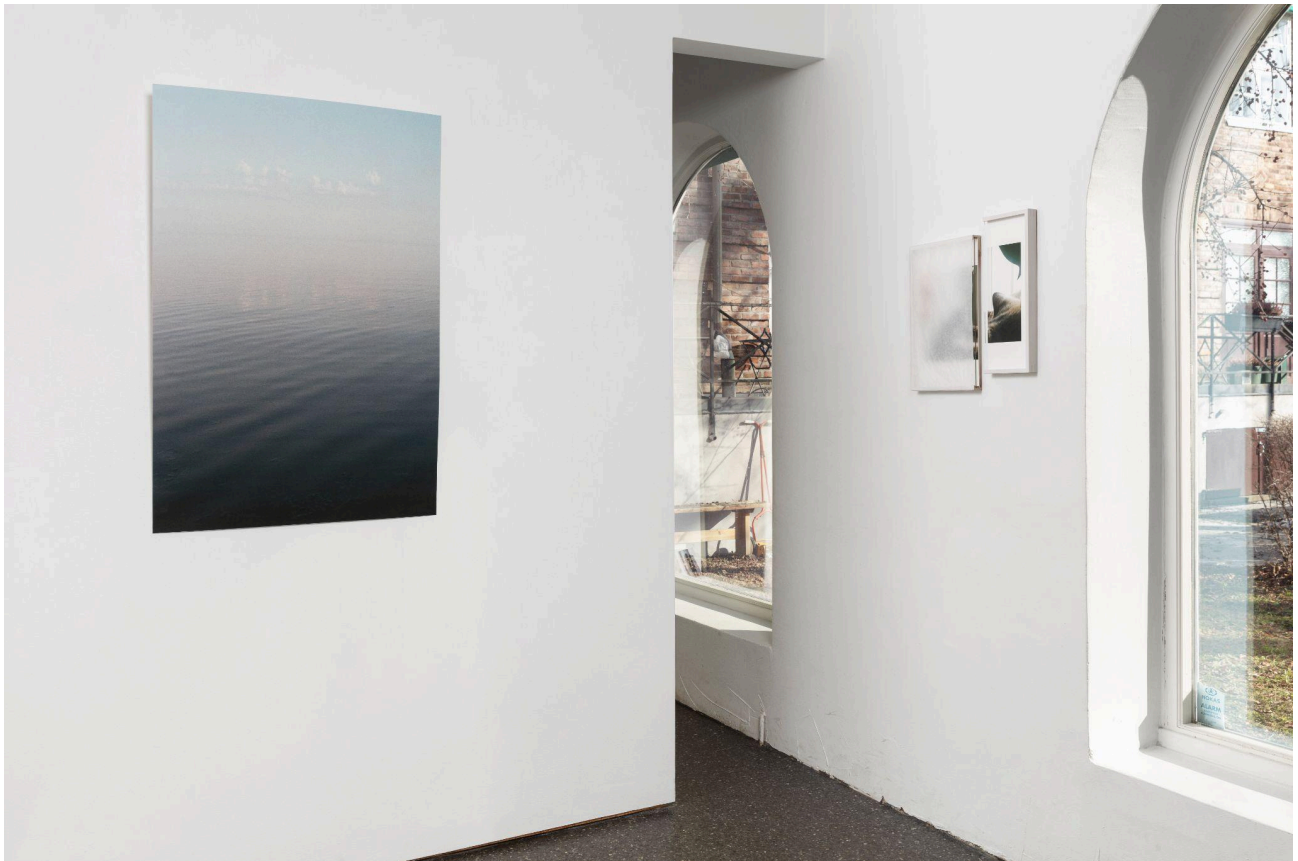
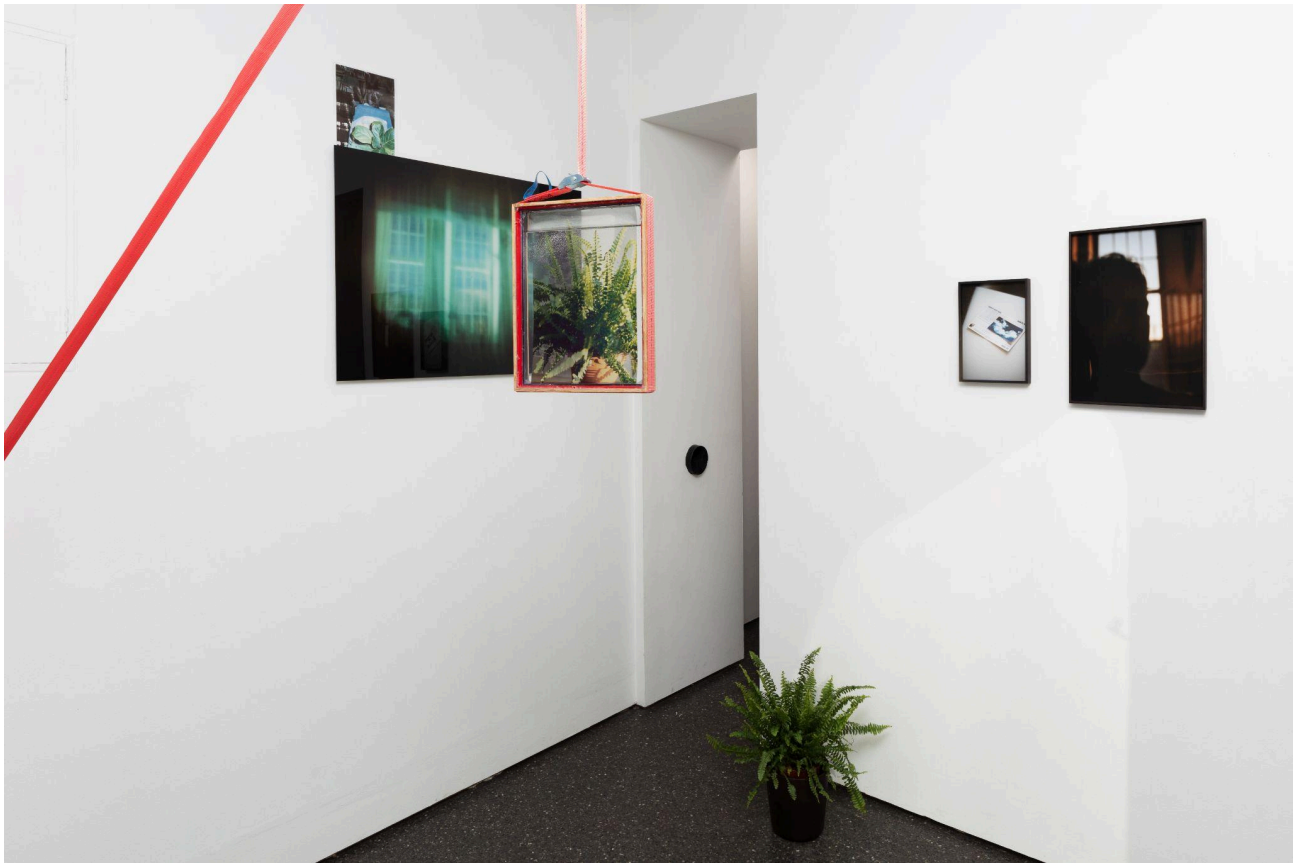


Exhibition views Tallinn 2022



Photos from Oslo 2024





First part

The exhibition begins with an angled natural wood wall, with a large passepartout covering part of the wall. Wall is supported with hanging ropes. On the built wall is the photo “The Answer Echoes” and next to it is a low podium with a plant that directs the viewer on a journey along the desired trajectory.

The photo “The Answer Echoes” is a small sensitive photo, with an awkward lowish positioning that conveys the feeling of tenderness, insecurity and flexibility that hopefully, the viewer will find from this project/self-expression.

On the podium is a fern, that in different cultures symbolises humility, new beginnings and the importance of family. In sync with my suffering, this plant has repeatedly tried to die off and has needed to be revived.





“vastus kaja”
translation “the answer echoes”
Archival Inkjet print, framed with museum glass
~50x30cm
2021

Second part

Next, the viewer is guided to the core of the show. Presented as a diptych, giving out a tone about going through anxiety and loneliness.

The left piece “i knew myself better than i do now” is a moment of abandonment with promising light and shattering tonality and shadows.

The work on the right “stars, they go like the last light of the sun, all in a blaze” is a moment just before leaving. It is also the first photograph I made after this whole life-art-project started. The window shows a harsh winter that spreads over the books, that will be taken away from this home. In the foreground, you can see picture frames, where “family” photos have been removed from the walls and placed facedown on the table.

Under the diptych is a large museum board 180x360cm, slightly bent in the bottom. this gives out the feeling of openness, but at the same time keeping viewers from getting close to the actual work.



Sidepiece to the diptych is a lonely family photo removed from the wall. Two small irregular screws have been screwed into the wall, leaving visible some measurement marks, showing how the photo was mounted as a surprise and in a hurry. Giving out and emphasising emptiness, where memories and shared experiences used to hang on the wall.

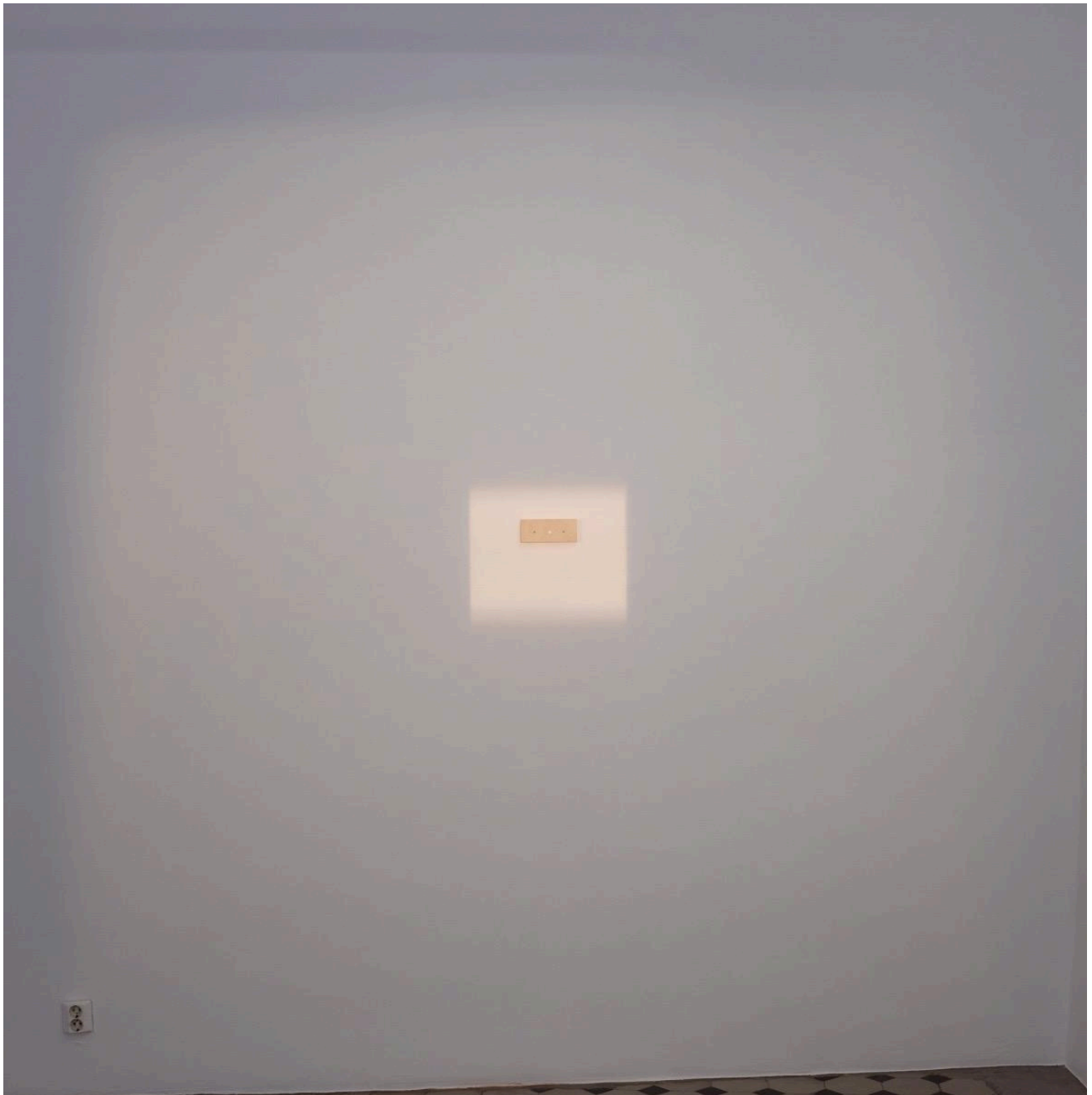
Under the hanging spot is this photo, taken down from the living room wall, where the face of the former lover is lost/covered with a natural linen cloth, slightly covering the photo, but still giving out the necessary emotions and hints.

There will be enough space left around the piece to give it the importance it deserves.



Opposite to the broken family photo is an installation piece. A theatre light shining a rectangular light on the wall, with a lonely frame hanging piece screwed to the wall.

Part of the installation is also a carousel slide projector, that has empty negative slides inside, and is just projecting a wall size light, that in every 10-15 seconds blinks, when it switches to the next slide. Projecting the lost and forgotten memories on top of the gone family portrait.



On the end wall is the piece, translation “always walking hand in hand, what we decide to remember and what to forget”.

I went back to this spot at lake Peipsi in the summer of 2021. One year before that me and my girlfriend were camping there. Later that year, as we were breaking up and discussing the process, she said “that moment near lake Pepsi, was the last time we were truly happy together”.

That’s why I went back to capture the moment and capture the location back to myself.



“käivad alati käsikäes.
mida otsustame mäletada ja mida unustada”
translation “always walking hand in hand
what we decide to remember and what to forget”
2021

The last accord of the show is a photo hanging near the exit. I will hang a translucent natural fabric that covers the backside of the frame and creates a soft surrounding around the piece.

This photo “padi märjaks” straight translation “getting the pillow wet” is of the post-it i saw when for the first time i came back to my home that was left empty. Text on the note “Aitäh kõige eest”, the translation “thanks for everything” was a painful prick that has remained an important symbol for looking into myself.

At the same time, it is the last knot, that connects the whole exhibition together with its positive reflections of windows and light. And gives the viewer and artist the opportunity to believe in a happy ending.



“padi märjaks”
kind of translation “pillow, wet”
Archival Inkjet print, framed with museum glass
~40x30cm
2021

Taavi Rekkaro (b. 1988) has studied graphic art at the Estonian Academy of Arts. Besides his artistic practice he works with artists' projects in Artproof and still has no idea what happens after this project.

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Exhibition description

Personal story, an exhibition about self-adaptation and survival, figuring out how to continue living. Since I graduated from Arts Academy I couldn't find a position or any space in the art world. Nothing seemed important or necessary enough, that I would want or need to present it to anyone through my artwork. Still all this time I have worked daily with artists and listened to stories and ideas, about why and how they express themselves. At the same time, I have been telling myself, "I am not worth enough", that I shouldn't show or express myself and my art.

At the end of 2020, ten years after graduation from the Academy of Arts, I found myself at the moment when my long-time partner decided to leave and follow love. Directed by the shock, I suddenly realised how burnt-out I was and found myself in depression again.

As I tried to adjust to the blows I realised how part of me wanted, even needed to catch and share these moments. Motivation to capture and execute these glances, not to suppress love, emotions or anger, but to feel, how is it to actually be the real me and live.

Exhibition works have come from this anxiety and give the viewer a chance to live through my fears, pain and attempts to move on. To adapt to the way I have lived a false-me life for years, that has only dug me down deeper.